Depression among neurodivergent people is very often the accumulated cost of years of masking and unmet needs, rather than something arriving out of nowhere. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Depression is a persistent lowering of mood, energy, interest and self-worth that lasts weeks or longer and doesn't lift with rest or good news. It's a medical condition, not a mood or an attitude. For many neurodivergent people it's tangled up with burnout, and treating both matters.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Not sadness so much as the volume turned down on everything, including sadness.
- Things you love feeling like admin.
- Being tired in a way sleep doesn't touch.
- Small tasks — a shower, a reply — becoming genuinely enormous.
- Knowing exactly how irrational the self-criticism is, and believing it anyway.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"Cheer up, it might never happen."	Depression isn't about circumstances, which is what makes it so hard to argue with.
"They're being lazy."	Effort is the thing depression removes. What you're seeing is the illness.
"Just get some exercise."	Exercise genuinely helps and is also nearly impossible mid-episode. Both are true.
"They've got nothing to be depressed about."	It doesn't require a reason. It isn't a response to your assessment of their life.
"It's just burnout."	They overlap heavily for neurodivergent people. Worth treating both, not choosing.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Depth of thought and honesty about hard things.

Compassion for others struggling — no performance required.

Realism that can be genuinely useful.

Considerable endurance; getting through a day like this is not nothing.

Insight into their own mind, hard won.

What actually helps

- ☐ Turn up without requiring anything
- ☐ Keep inviting, even after refusals
- ☐ Notice small things without praising loudly
- ☐ Do the task with them, not for them
- ☐ Support treatment — it works
- ☐ Ask directly how bad it is

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

"I'm coming round Tuesday, no need to tidy."

"Shall we do it together?"

"How bad is it, honestly?"

LESS HELPFUL

"Others have it worse."

"You just need a holiday."

"Have you tried being positive?"

You are not the illness. And this is treatable — genuinely, reliably treatable.

If you are struggling right now, you don't have to wait until it gets worse. In the UK you can call Samaritans free on 116 123, any time, or contact your GP. Elsewhere, your local crisis line or doctor is the place to start.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk